

Word family: **cramp / cramps / cramped / cramping**

Base word: **cramp**

Forms: **cramps, cramped, cramping**

Important adjective: **cramped**

Part of speech: **noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adjective through **cramped** (形容詞)**

Your sentence:

> “In a city defined by **cramped flats**, soaring rents and limited public space...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **cramped** means **uncomfortably small or confined, with too little space for people to move or live comfortably**.

繁體中文： **狹窄擠迫的；空間太小、令人活動或生活不舒服的**

中文翻譯：

> “...a city defined by **cramped flats** ...”

「.....一個以**狹窄擠迫的住宅單位**、高昂租金和有限公共空間為特徵的城市.....」

Here:

cramped flat = 面積很小、空間不足，令人感到侷促擠迫的住宅

1. **cramp = sudden painful tightening of a muscle (身體) — 抽筋；痙攣**

This is the most familiar noun meaning.

Meaning: A sudden, painful, involuntary tightening of a muscle.

Practice 1

> “I got a **cramp** in my leg while swimming.”

「我游泳時腿部**抽筋**了。」

Practice 2

> “She woke up with a painful calf **cramp**.”

「她醒來時小腿發生痛苦的**肌肉痙攣 / 抽筋**。」

****cramp = 肌肉突然不受控制地收緊，通常伴隨疼痛****

Common:

- * leg cramp
- * muscle cramp
- * calf cramp
- * stomach cramps

2. ****cramps = recurring abdominal/menstrual pain (腹痛 / 經痛) — 痙攣性疼痛；經痛****

The plural ****cramps**** is especially common for painful contractions in the abdomen.

Practice 3

> “She was suffering from stomach ****cramps****.”

「她正受到****腹部痙攣痛****困擾。」

Practice 4

> “She gets severe menstrual ****cramps****.”

「她會有嚴重的****經痛****。」

****cramps = 因肌肉或器官收縮而出現的陣發性疼痛****

For strict counting, this belongs to Meaning 1 rather than being a separate core meaning.

3. ****cramp = cause a muscle to tighten painfully (動詞) — 使抽筋；使痙攣****

As a verb, ****cramp**** can mean causing a muscle to contract painfully.

Practice 5

> “My leg ****cramped**** during the race.”

「我比賽期間腿部****抽筋****了。」

Practice 6

> “Sitting in that position made my foot **cramp**.”

「一直用那個姿勢坐着令我的腳**抽筋**。」

cramp = 肌肉發生 / 引起不自主而疼痛的收縮

This is the verb counterpart of Meaning 1.

4. **cramp** = restrict movement because there is too little space (空間) — 使侷促；限制活動空間

This is the branch behind **cramped flats**.

Meaning: To restrict someone or something because the available physical space is too limited.

Practice 7

> “The narrow seat **cramped** his legs.”

「狹窄的座位令他的雙腿**活動空間受限**。」

Practice 8

> “Too much furniture **cramped** the room.”

「太多家具令房間顯得非常**擠迫 / 侷促**。」

cramp = 因空間不足而限制活動、伸展或舒適程度

This develops naturally into the adjective **cramped**.

5. **cramped** = too small / confined for comfort (狹窄) — 狹窄的；擠迫的；侷促的

This is the **exact passage sense**.

Practice 9 — Original

> “Many people live in **cramped flats**.”

「很多人住在**狹窄擠迫的單位**裡。」

Practice 10

> “The office felt dark and **cramped**.”

「那間辦公室感覺昏暗而**侷促**。」

Practice 11

> “Five people were sharing a **cramped** room.”

「五個人共用一間**擠迫狹小的**房間。」

cramped = 空間太小或太擠，以致令人感到不舒服、難以活動

Common:

- * cramped apartment
- * cramped flat
- * cramped room
- * cramped conditions
- * cramped seat

6. **cramped** = physically uncomfortable because the body cannot move freely (身體姿勢) — 伸展不開的；侷促的

A person can feel **cramped** when there is not enough room to move.

Practice 12

> “I felt **cramped** in the back seat.”

「我坐在後座時覺得非常**侷促、伸展不開**。」

Practice 13

> “There was hardly enough legroom, so everyone felt **cramped**.”

「腿部空間幾乎不夠，所以大家都覺得很**擠迫不舒服**。」

For strict counting, this stays under Meaning 5.

7. **cramp** = restrict freedom, development, creativity, etc. (比喻) — 限制；束縛；妨礙

****Cramp**** can figuratively mean preventing someone or something from developing, acting, or expressing itself freely.

Practice 14

> “Too many rules can ****cramp**** creativity.”

「太多規則可能會****限制 / 束縛****創意。」

Practice 15

> “The lack of funding ****cramped**** the project’s development.”

「資金不足****限制了****項目的發展。」

****cramp** = 因限制或約束而令某人 / 某事不能自由發展或運作******

This is a major figurative extension of the physical-space sense.

8. ****cramp someone’s style** = restrict how freely someone can behave (固定表達) — 束縛某人 ; 妨礙發揮******

Practice 16

> “Having his parents there really ****cramped his style****.”

「父母在場真的令他感到很****束手束腳 / 不能自在發揮****。」

Practice 17

> “These regulations are beginning to ****cramp our style****.”

「這些規定開始令我們做事****受到限制****。」

****cramp someone’s style** = 限制某人的自由、個人做法或表現方式******

This is a fixed idiom under Meaning 7.

9. ****cramped** = tightly packed or written with too little space (文字 / 書寫) — 擠得很密的 ; 難讀的******

****Cramped**** can describe handwriting, printing, or layout that is compressed into too little space.

Practice 18

> “His handwriting is small and ****cramped****.”

「他的字寫得很小，而且****擠得很密 / 很難閱讀****。」

Practice 19

> “The page looked ****cramped**** because there was too much text.”

「那一頁因文字太多而顯得非常****擠迫****。」

****cramped** = 元素、字體或內容被壓縮在過小空間裡，缺乏舒展感******

For strict counting, this belongs to the spatial-restriction branch rather than requiring a new core sense.

10. ****cramp** = clamp-like tool for holding things together (工具，專門) — 夾具；固定夾******

There is also a technical noun sense.

A ****cramp**** can be a tool used to hold pieces firmly together while they are being worked on, glued, etc., similar to a ****clamp****.

Practice 20

> “The carpenter held the pieces together with a ****cramp****.”

「木匠用****夾具****把那些部件固定在一起。」

This usage is especially associated with British technical/carpentry terminology.

****Database status:**** genuine but lower-priority specialist sense.

Useful expression: ****writer's cramp** — 書寫痙攣******

****Writer's cramp**** can refer to painful or involuntary muscle contractions associated with writing, and in medical contexts can refer to a task-specific movement disorder.

Practice 21

> “He developed **writer’s cramp** after years of intensive handwriting.”

「他多年大量書寫後出現了**書寫痙攣**。」

This belongs to the bodily-cramp branch rather than being a separate core meaning.

Important distinction: **cramped** vs **crowded**

This is particularly useful for your passage.

crowded

means:

> containing too many people or things.

cramped

means:

> physically too small or confined for comfort.

Compare:

> a crowded restaurant

> = 餐廳裡人很多

> a cramped flat

> = 單位本身空間很小、很侷促

A room can be cramped even with only one person inside.

Important distinction: **cramped** vs **small**

small

is neutral and simply describes size.

cramped

adds a negative judgment:

> there is ****not enough space for comfort or movement****.

> small apartment

> cramped apartment

The second suggests discomfort.

Important distinction: ****cramped vs narrow****

****narrow****

means not wide.

****cramped****

means generally too confined or lacking usable space.

> narrow corridor

> cramped room

A room can be cramped without being especially narrow.

Important distinction: ****cramped vs confined****

****confined****

means restricted to a small or limited area.

****cramped****

adds the sense of physical discomfort caused by limited space.

> confined space

> cramped living conditions

Important distinction: ****cramp vs spasm****

****cramp****

usually refers to painful sustained muscle tightening.

spasm

is broader and can mean any sudden involuntary muscular contraction.

A spasm may be brief or repetitive; a cramp often feels sustained and painful.

Important distinction: **cramp vs ache**

ache

= continuous dull pain

cramp

= pain caused by involuntary muscular contraction

> stomach ache

> stomach cramps

These are not identical.

Grammar note: **cramped is often a true descriptive adjective**

Although historically/formally related to **cramp**, **cramped** frequently behaves like an ordinary adjective:

> cramped flat

> cramped office

> cramped conditions

> feel cramped

So learners should not always try to interpret it as an active passive construction such as "something cramped the flat."

Countability note

As a bodily noun:

- > a cramp
- > several cramps

But certain health contexts strongly favour plural:

- > stomach cramps
- > menstrual cramps

As the tool noun:

- > a cramp
- > two cramps

Different contexts distinguish the senses.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is compact:

- * **cramp**
- * **cramps**
- * **cramped**
- * **cramping**

The semantic network has two major images:

1. **something becomes painfully tightened**
2. **something is restricted because there is not enough room/freedom**

From #2 develop:

- * cramped flats
- * cramped seats
- * cramped handwriting
- * cramp creativity
- * cramp someone's style

The carpentry **cramp = clamp** is a genuinely distinct specialist noun.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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cramp — muscle	肌肉突然不自主收緊並造成疼痛；抽筋 / 痙攣

cramps — abdominal/menstrual	腹部、子宮等反覆收縮造成的痙攣性疼痛	
cramp — verb, muscle	發生 / 引起肌肉抽筋或痙攣	
cramp — restrict space	因空間不足而限制活動、伸展或舒適程度	
cramped — space	空間太小、太擠，以致令人不舒服或難以活動	
cramped — writing/layout	字體 / 內容被擠在狹小空間中，顯得密集侷促	
cramp — figurative restriction	限制、束縛某人或某事的自由發展 / 發揮	
cramp someone's style	令某人不能自由自在地做事或表現	
cramp — tool	用來固定物件的夾具；較專門	

For your original sentence

> “In a city defined by ****cramped flats****, soaring rents and limited public space...”

The exact meaning is:

****cramped = 住宅空間太小、太侷促，令人難以舒適生活或活動****

So:

> ****cramped flats****

= ****狹窄擠迫的住宅單位****

This is stronger than simply:

> ****small flats****

because ****cramped**** explicitly suggests ****insufficient space and discomfort****.

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****cramp****:

1. ****painful involuntary muscle contraction****
2. ****restrict physical space/movement or figuratively restrict freedom/development****
3. ****technical noun: clamp-like holding tool****

I would keep ****cramped = confined/uncomfortably small**** as a major adjective extension of #2, merge handwriting/layout uses into the same spatial branch, and keep ****cramp someone's style**** as a fixed figurative expression.